

BUS 719: Managing People and Organizations

Instructor: Dr. Gervase Bushe

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Email: bushe@sfu.ca

Phone: 604.986.1819

Course Description

The course combines readings, videos, cases, exercises, and your experiences to explore how we manage people through the design of organizations and organizational change. The first part of the course will develop an appreciation for the inherent dilemmas of organizing and, in particular, the contradictory pressures for control/efficiency/reliability/performance and for flexibility/innovation/adaptation/learning. We will learn a common language of organization design so we can talk together about our experience. We will look at the main contingencies that have impacted how organizations have been, and continue to be, designed. We will try to connect abstract models to your lived experiences and those of other students.

The second part of the course will consider traditional, top-down change management and examine newer, more emergent approaches to organizational change that show promise for addressing complex challenges and creating greater organizational agility.

Objectives

The purpose of this course is to explore how to manage people and organizations from an executive perspective. You will learn about models of organizational design and organizational change, and consider them in light of contemporary issues.

Book and Materials

A set of selected readings and cases is described in the course schedule, below. All readings and videos are available online. You will also need a copy of the short book, *The Dynamics of Generative Change*, available on [Amazon](https://www.amazon.com/dp/0674043350). Cases will be available for purchase through Harvard.

Assessment Summary

Individual	Polarity Analysis	20%
	Analysis of Organizational Structure and Power	30%
	Participation in Online Discussions & Peer Reviews	10%
Group	Analyzing Organizational Change Success and Failures	40%
	Total	100%

1. Polarity Analysis (20% - due by midnight May 31)

After instruction on the nature of polarities and their centrality to core dilemmas in organizations and change, you will analyze how an organization you have worked in managed a polarity and develop a more robust understanding of that polarity.

You are to examine one polarity in any organization you have worked in, past or present, that was not managed well. A polarity is an interdependent pair (neither can exist without the other) that appears to make opposing demands on an organization. There are two parts to the assignment. The first is to analyze how this polarity operated within that organization and the negative effects of its management. The second is to propose how the organization could have better managed this polarity.

See the document Polarity Assignment for more information.

2. Analysis of Organizational Structure and Power (30% - due by midnight June 21)

You will describe the design of structure and power in an organization you are familiar with. To qualify as an organization, and not a group, there must be more than 50 employees. You will use the models provided in the lectures and readings to create this description and identify where the design is/was effective and where it could be or has been better.

See the document Organizational Analysis Assignment for more information.

3. Analyzing Organizational Change Success and Failures (40% - due by July 7)

Your team will interview others about their experiences of successful and unsuccessful organizational change. You will examine why each change was initiated, how the process unfolded, and the reciprocal impact of organizational culture, leadership, structure, and processes, and look for patterns that help predict success and failure.

See the document Team Assignment for more information.

4. Participation: Online Discussions and Peer Reviews (10% - due weekly)

For this exercise, you start with 20 marks toward your final grade. Each week, you are to make a comment (no more than 300 words) on anything that struck you in the materials due for that week. This is due 48 hours before class. You will also be randomly assigned to review and comment on two other students' comments. This must be completed by midnight the day before the class. This is all done in Canvas and is automatically tracked. Each time you fail to provide a comment by the due date, you lose one mark. Each time you fail to review a peer's work, you lose one mark. This only begins for the May 14 class.

Course Policies

Use of Zoom

Lectures delivered on Zoom may be recorded by your instructor. As a result, Simon Fraser University may collect your image, voice, name, personal views and opinions, and coursework under the legal authority of the University Act and the Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy. This information is related directly to and needed by the University to support student learning only (i.e., posting in the Learning Management System for students to review). If you have any questions about the collection and use of this information, please get in touch with your instructor.

Reading and Course Schedule

M	Date	Topic	Pre-work
1	May 7	Foundations of Organization Design	Video Lecture 1
2	May 14	Org Culture and Dilemmas of Organizing	Video Lecture 2 Polarity videos: 1) https://vimeo.com/148574711 2) https://vimeo.com/154838501 Schein, E. H. (2016). Part One: Defining the Structure of Culture. In <i>Organizational Culture and Leadership</i> . John Wiley & Sons, Incorporated. (Canvas)
3	May 21	Organizational Structure	Video Lecture 3 <u>Mintzberg: Structure In 5's: A Synthesis of The Research on Organization Design</u> Case: PMC-Sierra 2 (Canvas)
4	May 28	Power and Organization Design	Video Lecture 4 Morgan: <i>Interests, Conflict and Power</i> (chap 6) (Canvas) Semler: <u>Managing Without Managers</u> Holocracy: https://www.holaspirit.com/blog/holacracy • Recommended: <u>Holocracy Constitution 5.0</u> Case: Organization Design at iQmetrix (Coursepack)
	May 31	No class	Assignment on Polarity Analysis due
5	June 4	Top-Down Change	Video Lecture 5 Kotter: <u>Leading Change</u> ten Have et al: Reconsidering Change Management, (Chap 3): <u>18 Leading Assumptions in Change Practice</u> Case: Keda's SAP Implementation (Coursepack)
6	June 11	Hi Engagement Change	Video Lecture 6 Bushe & Lewis: <u>Three Strategies of Change in Organization Development</u> <u>Higgs & Rowland: What Does It Take to Implement Change Successfully?</u> Examples of Large Group Engagement Methods: • Harrison Owen – <i>Open Space Technology</i> videos: 1) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WQj12jmLGr4

			2) https://www.youtube.com/watch?time_continue=381&v=APD7oQ3xrSA • Weisbord & Janoff: <i>Future Search</i> video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=b-E0JaVZS9c • Cooperrider & Whitney: <i>Appreciative Inquiry</i> video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?app=desktop&feature=youtu.be&v=uJEQBx4TMiM Case: Jet Blue Airways: A New Beginning (Coursepack)
7	June 18	Generative Change	Video Lecture 7 Snowden and Boone: A Leader's Framework for Decision-Making Case & Reading: Bushe, <i>The Dynamics of Generative Change</i>
	June 21	No class	Organizational analysis due
8	June 25	Impacts of Artificial Intelligence on Organizations	Khanfar et al: Factors Influencing the adoption of AI (begin reading from Results, starting on page 3. Results and findings) Jones: 80 out of every 200 employees exist to manage handoffs that AI agents are eliminating (Canvas) Jones: Companies using AI to cut headcount are making the most expensive mistake of 2026 (Canvas)
9	July 2	Summary and Completion	No readings or cases due
	July 7	No class	Team assignments due

Academic Integrity

SFU's Academic Integrity website <http://www.sfu.ca/students/academicintegrity.html> is filled with information on what is meant by academic dishonesty, where you can find resources to help with your studies, and the consequences of cheating. Check out the site for more information and videos that help explain the issues in plain English.

Each student is responsible for his or her conduct and its impact on the University community. Academic dishonesty, in whatever form, is ultimately destructive of the values of the University. Furthermore, it is unfair and discouraging to the majority of students who pursue their studies honestly. Scholarly integrity is required of all members of the University. <http://www.sfu.ca/policies/gazette/student/s10-01.html>

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY: YOUR WORK, YOUR SUCCESS

About the Course Instructor



Dr. Gervase Bushe, Professor

In 2016, Dr. Gervase Bushe, Professor of Leadership and Organization Development, was added to HR Magazine (UK) 's list of the 30 most influential HR thinkers in the world and ranked 12th in 2020. He studies organizational change, organizational learning, leadership and leadership development, teams and team building, change agents and change agency. He has twice won the Douglas McGregor Award for his research. His bestselling book, [*Clear Leadership*](#), has been translated into 10 languages with more in process. His 2015 co-edited book [*Dialogic Organization Development: The Theory and Practice of Transformational Change*](#) has widely influenced both the research and practice of organizational change. With an extensive background in helping leaders create great organizations, Gervase consults with major corporations

across a variety of sectors, including Business Objects, Telus, General Motors, Fraser Health Authority, Citizenship and Immigration Canada, Boehringer Ingelheim, and BC Hydro. His leadership development programs are licensed for delivery worldwide through ClearLeadership.com. A chapter on his life and work can be found in the [*Palgrave Handbook of Organizational Change Thinkers*](#).